FIVE KEY CHALLENGES

1. With a fragile coalition government to manage now, disputes over policy are a given
2. Lack of administrative experience will raise doubts about his government's effectiveness. Add to that the weight of public expectation
3. TN's Rs 10 lakh crore public debt will worsen with TVK's high-cost welfare promises. Fiscal responsibility will be a big challenge
4. Personal charisma and a deeply felt need for change carried the day for Vijay in election. Must now transform the TVK into a structured political entity for future success
5. Maintaining cordial ties with the BJP-led Centre despite contentious issues—NEET, Hindi imposition, governor's role etc.



SELFIE TIME The new CM with Congress's Rahul Gandhi

ANI

FISCAL STABILITY

Yet beneath all the symbolism lies a more serious question: what exactly does Vijay intend to do with the economy he has inherited? Accusing the previous regime of leaving "empty coffers" is alright in the short term because it lowers public expectations and gives room to explain difficult decisions. But the statement also creates pressure on the government to present a clear economic roadmap fairly quickly. Tamil Nadu is the only state in India to record double-digit real economic growth for two consecutive years (FY25 and 26). It also has the second highest per capita income in the country and is one of India's most industrialised regions, with deep investments in manufacturing, automobiles, electronics and healthcare.

Observers cite all this to say that any perception of fiscal instability can have consequences beyond politics, affecting investor confidence and administrative continuity. Vijay's government will, therefore, be judged not only by whether it exposes financial stress but also by whether it can reassure industry, the welfare beneficiary class and the bureaucracy that the state's long-term stability remains intact. "The new CM spoke too soon," says a senior political commentator. "He should have waited till he actually got to grips with his office."

Vijay and the TVK could rack up a humongous bill with its pre-poll promises. Analysts say it would add up to an outgo of nearly Rs 1 lakh crore every year, one-third of the state's total revenues

Meanwhile, the making of the 'Vijay legend' has started in right earnest. In the opening House session, new speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar invoked the late CMs MGR and Jayalalithaa in the same breath as Vijay, all the while calling the latter a "living MGR". Since the election results came in, supporters and sections of the TVK leadership have framed Vijay's rise within the same long tradition of cinema-driven mass politics in Tamil Nadu. Even his public appearances now, including the distinct black coat and carefully choreographed entries, are a confirmation of this.

But the comparisons also underline the scale of the challenge before him. MGR and Jayalalithaa succeeded not just because they were charismatic film stars, but also because they transformed the charm into durable political structures. Both eventually built a highly cen-